

Introduction

It all started with an angry programmer in 1990. A Sun Microsystems Software Engineer Patrick Naughton, aged 25, was disgusted with his job at Sun. He had the impossible job of making different software APIs from dozens of languages, platform OS's and vendors all to work as one. It was impossible. Naughton announced to CEO Scott McNealy that he was quitting Sun. Pat was going to join NeXT, because Sun was a mess. McNealy asked Pat to write a memo outlining his gripes. The CEO asked Pat to suggest a solution, stating "Think As if you were God." This was the initiation of the project leading upto Java.

By January 1995, the Internet had taken off. Bill Joy, one of Sun's founders, realised the needs of the Web reliability, platform independence, and security exactly matched the characteristics of Oak, which had just been renamed Java. Although Java had not yet been officially released in 1995, it was spreading like wildfire among developers. Then, something very lucky happened. Two months later, at the SunWorld conference, Marc Andreessen stepped on stage and announced that "Java is real, and it will be incorporated into Netscape Navigator 2.0."

Times have changed. The entity formerly known as Sun Microsystems now belongs to Oracle. What hasn't changed is the significance of Java in rich multimedia applications and the way we consume them. In this Fast Track to Java, we have tried to cover the most important topics.

The Java Platform is unique, because it can work without modification on any platform, on any operating system, if that platform has a "Java Virtual Machine." In a typical C program, the source code is compiled into a native machine language module that consists of 1's and 0's. The machine language is specifically tailored to one OS, be it Windows, Mac or Linux. Therefore, it is impossible for one object module to be portable between platforms. In contrast to conventional programming languages, a Java program